

AP ENGLISH LANGUAGE & COMPOSITION · THE UNIVERSAL STUDY GUIDE

MCQ Mastery · 3 Essays · The Sophistication Point · Phrases That Score

Tag legend: [FLOOR-4] = floor (must-have) [STRETCH-5] = what gets you the 5

PAGE 1 | MATH OF YOUR TARGET · THE UNIVERSAL ESSAY RUBRIC · THE SOPHISTICATION POINT

THE MATH OF YOUR TARGET — what you actually need to score (~75%)

Section	Weight	Total Points	Get this many	What that takes
MCQ — Reading (~23 q)	23%	23 questions	18 / 23	Close-read passage; identify rhetorical purpose, tone, function
MCQ — Writing (~22 q)	22%	22 questions	16 / 22	Recognize style, concision, grammar, transitions, evidence
Synthesis Essay	18.3%	6 points	5 / 6	Thesis + 3 sources used to BUILD argument + sophistication
Rhetorical Analysis	18.3%	6 points	5 / 6	Thesis + device → effect → purpose, repeated
Argument Essay	18.3%	6 points	5 / 6	Position (qualify is best) + 2–3 strong examples + complexity

That's a 5. The MCQ is half the grade — most kids who miss the 5 do it on MCQ pacing, not essays.

THE UNIVERSAL ESSAY RUBRIC — same 6 pts on all 3 essays

Pts	What it scores	How it's graded
1	Thesis (Row A)	Defensible thesis that responds to the prompt with a line of reasoning. Just state your position . Easy point — almost every prompt should produce one.
0–4	Evidence + Commentary (Row B)	Graded on a single 0–4 scale (NOT 4 separate points). The scale: 0 = no/inaccurate evidence; 1 = simple summary; 2 = specific evidence but generic commentary; 3 = specific evidence + commentary explaining how/why it supports thesis [FLOOR-4]; 4 = sophisticated commentary explaining complexity, tension, or interplay [STRETCH-5].
1	Sophistication (Row C)	Awarded if your essay does ONE of: crafts a nuanced argument; explores tension/complexity; uses style effectively; situates argument in broader context. Rare (~10% of essays earn it). [STRETCH-5]

THE SOPHISTICATION POINT — 4 paths to earn it [5]

Pick ONE per essay. You only need it on 1–2 of your 3 essays to be solidly in 5 territory.

1. NUANCED ARGUMENT — acknowledge complexity, tensions, ambiguity, or contradictions. "While X is generally true, the case of Y reveals a tension..." Don't argue in absolutes.

2. IMPLICATIONS / LIMITS — gesture at consequences or boundaries. "This argument matters because if pursued, it leads to..." or "This view holds in [context] but breaks down when..."

3. STYLE — your OWN writing demonstrates rhetorical skill. Vivid verbs, sentence variety, controlled tone, deliberate parallelism. **You become the rhetorician you're analyzing.**

4. BROADER CONTEXT — situate the argument in a larger conversation. "This rhetorical move reflects a broader [historical/cultural/philosophical] tradition of..." Connect to ideas beyond the immediate passage/prompt.

THE 4-vs-5 DIFFERENTIATOR ON THIS EXAM (the central insight)

A 4-scorer IDENTIFIES things accurately. A 5-scorer EXPLAINS how those things CREATE meaning and argument.

4-scorer: "The author uses anaphora."

5-scorer: "The author's anaphora — repeating 'we cannot' three times — accumulates moral weight, escalating from personal protest to collective imperative, persuading the audience that inaction is itself a choice."

Internalize this pattern: name the device → describe the effect → connect to the author's argument or purpose. This is the entire game on the Rhetorical Analysis essay, and a strong analog for the other two.

PAGE 2 | MCQ MASTERY · Reading + Writing · ~80 sec/question

READING SECTION (~23 q) — rhetorical analysis questions

You'll read 3–4 passages (nonfiction prose, often essays/letters/speeches). Each passage has 8–13 MCQs. ~80 sec per Q. Read passage first, then questions.

[5] BEFORE answering, identify the passage's purpose, audience, and tone in 30 seconds — write 3 words in the margin (e.g., "persuade lawmakers / educated public / urgent"). 70% of the questions hinge on these.

READING QUESTION TYPES — recognize them, answer faster [5]

Question phrasing	What it's actually asking + how to answer
"The primary purpose of the passage is to..."	Whole-passage purpose. Pick the verb that captures the main rhetorical aim (persuade / argue / critique / illustrate / refute). Eliminate options that focus on a sub-section.
"In the context of the passage, the phrase X most nearly means..."	Vocabulary in context. The dictionary definition is often a trap. Re-read the sentence + sentence before/after. Pick the meaning the AUTHOR is using here.
"The author's tone in lines 12–18 can best be described as..."	Tone. Look at diction (word choice). Bring tone vocab (Page 6) — "contemplative," "ironic," "indignant." Eliminate extremes if author is measured.
"The function of [phrase / sentence / paragraph] is to..."	Rhetorical function within the passage's structure. Ask: how does this piece contribute to the whole? Common answers: introduce counterargument, provide evidence, transition, qualify a claim, illustrate.
"The author's argument would be most strengthened/weakened by..."	Evidence evaluation. Pick the option that most directly supports/undercuts the THESIS, not a side claim.
"The author uses [device] in order to..."	Device → purpose. Don't pick "to use [device]" — that's circular. Pick what the device DOES rhetorically (emphasize, qualify, juxtapose).
"Which of the following best describes the rhetorical shift..."	Shifts. Look for transition words (however, yet, but, in contrast). Identify the before vs after mood/argument/strategy.

WRITING SECTION (~22 q) — revising/editing a sample essay

These test grammar, style, and rhetorical effectiveness. You'll be revising a hypothetical student essay. ~80 sec/Q.

Question type	What earns the point
"Which version best maintains the author's argument?"	Pick the option that adds specific evidence or strengthens connection to thesis . Eliminate vague generalities.
"Which is the most effective way to combine sentences X and Y?"	Look for logical relationship (cause-effect, contrast, addition). Pick subordinator/transition that captures it ("because," "although," "however"). Avoid run-ons.
"Which provides the most concise revision?"	Shorter is usually better unless meaning is lost. Cut redundancy ("each and every"), passive voice, nominalizations ("made a decision" → "decided").
"Which transition best fits between paragraphs?"	Identify relationship of paragraphs: contrast → "however/in contrast"; cause-effect → "as a result"; example → "for instance"; concession → "although".
"Which sentence should be deleted/added?"	Delete: irrelevant tangents, repetitions. Add: specific evidence, audience appeal, logical bridges.
"Which best uses parallel structure?"	All items in a list/series should match grammatically: "running, jumping, swimming" — not "running, jumping, to swim."

MCQ TRAPS — the wrong answers designed to fool [4]

- **Right idea, wrong scope.** Answer is true for one paragraph but the question asks about the whole passage.
- **Too extreme.** "Always," "never," "completely." Authors rarely commit to absolutes — eliminate.
- **Anachronism.** Answer projects modern values onto a 19th-century passage. Don't assume the author shares your views.
- **Trap of the obvious.** First option seems right because it restates the surface; the SOPHISTICATED answer captures rhetorical purpose. **Read all 4 before locking in.**
- **Tone overshoot.** Author is mildly critical; option says "furious." Pick the **more measured** option unless evidence is overwhelming.
- **Right answer to wrong question.** Answer is true historically but doesn't address what's asked. **Re-read the prompt** before locking in.

PAGE 3 | RHETORICAL ANALYSIS ESSAY · the most teachable essay · 40 min

The prompt: You'll get a passage (speech, letter, essay) + a tagline like "Read the following passage carefully. Then write an essay analyzing the rhetorical choices [author] makes to develop her argument."

Time budget: 5 min plan + 30 min write + 5 min revise = 40 min total.

ANNOTATE THE PASSAGE — the 5-min planning move that drives everything [5]

Margin notes: identify in 30 seconds — **SOAPSTone** (Speaker, Occasion, Audience, Purpose, Subject, Tone).

Underline + label: 6–10 rhetorical moves — anaphora, antithesis, juxtaposition, allusion, parallelism, shifts in tone, direct address, rhetorical questions, anecdotes.

Group by purpose: Cluster the moves by what they DO. Three clusters = three body paragraphs. (e.g., "establishes ethos," "appeals to shared values," "escalates urgency.")

THE BODY PARAGRAPH FORMULA — DEVICE → EFFECT → PURPOSE [5]

Every body paragraph should follow this 4-move structure:

1. TOPIC SENTENCE — name the rhetorical strategy + connect it to the author's overall argument. "To establish moral urgency, [author] employs accumulating anaphora that escalates the stakes of inaction."

2. EVIDENCE — quote or specifically reference a passage. "In repeating 'we cannot' three times in lines 12–17, the author..." **Use brief, surgical quotes — not whole sentences.**

3. COMMENTARY (this is where you score) [5] — explain HOW the device works rhetorically. **Don't just say "this emphasizes"** — explain WHY this particular emphasis matters HERE. "By stacking these refusals, the author transforms personal grievance into collective imperative; readers cannot dismiss the argument as one person's complaint."

4. CONNECTION TO PURPOSE — tie back to the overall rhetorical aim. "This shift from individual to collective grounds her broader call for legislative action."

THE "DEVICE → EFFECT → PURPOSE" UPGRADE [5]

A 4-scorer writes...	A 5-scorer writes...
"The author uses anaphora."	"The author's anaphora accumulates moral weight , transforming three private refusals into a public ethical demand."
"This emphasizes her point."	"This forces the reader into the speaker's position , where neutrality becomes complicity."
"The author uses pathos by describing the suffering."	"By foregrounding specific embodied details — the child's bruised hands, the cracked walls — the author bypasses statistical abstraction and makes the policy debate viscerally real."
"The shift in tone shows her seriousness."	"The shift from wry detachment to direct address in line 22 abandons the protective posture of irony, signaling that the argument has moved past argument and into appeal."

THESIS TEMPLATE FOR RHETORICAL ANALYSIS [5]

Don't write: "The author uses ethos, pathos, and logos." That's a 0-thesis.

Do write: "Through [strategy 1], [strategy 2], and [strategy 3], [author] [verb describing rhetorical action] [audience] to [purpose / effect]."

Example: "Through escalating anaphora, juxtaposed historical allusions, and a deliberate shift from detached observation to direct moral appeal, Lincoln transforms a private letter into a public reckoning with the costs of complacency."

[5] Notice what makes this thesis sophisticated: it names the strategies AND captures the author's rhetorical TRAJECTORY ("transforms... into...") — that movement = sophistication.

THE SOPHISTICATION MOVE FOR THIS ESSAY [5]

Easiest path: situate the rhetorical choices in a broader context. "This rhetorical posture — refusing to argue with opponents and instead invoking shared moral inheritance — echoes a tradition of American jeremiad from Winthrop through King." Context → sophistication point.

PAGE 4 | SYNTHESIS ESSAY · 6 sources, take a position · 40 min + 15-min reading window

The prompt: You'll get **6 sources** (essays, articles, charts, images, cartoons) on a contemporary issue + a prompt asking you to take a position. **You must cite at least 3 sources** (and you *should* — citing only 3 caps you at the 4-zone).

Time budget: 15 min reading window (read sources, plan) + 40 min writing.

READING THE SOURCES — 15-min strategy [5]

Skim once, take a position, re-skim with purpose. Don't read every source closely on first pass.

For each source, jot in margin (10 sec each): "A: pro X / measured" "B: con X / passionate" "C: data — supports X" "D: visual — anti X" "E: nuanced / qualifies" "F: historical context."

Pick a position. Take a stance — even a qualified one — not "I see both sides without committing." Indecision = no thesis.

Choose your 4 best sources (cite 4, not the minimum 3, to push past the 3-out-of-4 evidence ceiling). Pick a mix: at least one supports your position strongly, at least one you can engage critically.

THE THESIS — take a position with reasoning [5]

Weak (4-zone): "Standardized testing has both pros and cons." — wishy-washy, no position.

Strong (5-zone): "Although standardized testing offers efficient measurement at scale, its narrow vision of intelligence and its disparate impact on under-resourced students render it a tool of replication rather than meritocracy — and it should be displaced by holistic alternatives."

Template: "Although [counterargument's strongest claim], [your position] because [reason 1] and [reason 2]." The "although" front-loads sophistication.

BODY PARAGRAPH STRUCTURE — "They Say / I Say" with 2 sources per paragraph [5]

1. TOPIC SENTENCE — make ONE specific claim that advances your thesis. (Not the thesis again — a sub-claim.)

2. EVIDENCE FROM SOURCE A — paraphrase or briefly quote. **Cite by tag:** "(Source A)" or use an attributive phrase: "As economist Smith argues in Source A..."

3. COMMENTARY — explain how Source A supports your sub-claim. *Don't summarize — analyze.*

4. EVIDENCE FROM SOURCE B (or counterargument source) — bring in another source. If it's a counter-source, **acknowledge then refute or qualify.**

5. SYNTHESIS — explain how the two sources together build YOUR argument. **This is where the 5-vs-4 lives** — it's not enough to cite; you must MAKE THEM TALK TO EACH OTHER.

THE SCORE-DEFINING MOVE: SOURCE INTEGRATION [5]

A 4-scorer cites...	A 5-scorer integrates...
"Source A says testing is biased. Source B says it's efficient."	"Source B's defense of efficiency rests on a measurement assumption that Source A — by documenting the racial achievement gap as a function of resource access — directly undermines: efficiency in measuring the wrong thing isn't efficiency at all."
Cites 3 sources sequentially (one per paragraph)	Layers 4–5 sources with one per paragraph supporting + a counter-source addressed and refuted
Quotes long passages	Uses brief, surgical paraphrase with attribution; quotes only the most loaded phrases
States that sources "agree" or "disagree"	Explains the specific terms on which sources agree/disagree, and what that reveals

THE SOPHISTICATION MOVE FOR SYNTHESIS [5]

Easiest path: acknowledge complexity. "This issue resists simple resolution because it sits at the intersection of [value A] and [value B] — both of which are defensible." Then take a position THAT NAVIGATES rather than ignores the tension. **Acknowledging tension while still taking a position = sophistication point.**

PAGE 5 | ARGUMENT ESSAY · defend / challenge / qualify · 40 min

The prompt: You'll get a quote, claim, or short passage with a directive: **defend, challenge, or qualify** the position with your own evidence. **No sources are provided** — your evidence comes from literature, history, current events, scientific studies, or *occasionally* personal experience.

THE 3 PROMPT TYPES — and which to pick [5]

Move	When to use it	Sophistication ceiling
Defend	Quote/claim is reasonable; you mostly agree	Hard to earn sophistication — too much agreement reads flat
Challenge	Quote/claim is overstated or wrong	Medium — but watch for strawmanning
Qualify	Quote/claim is partially right — true here, false there	HIGHEST. Qualifying = inherently nuanced = sophistication-friendly. Default to this unless the prompt makes one extreme clearly correct.

EVIDENCE BANK — the 5 categories you can pull from

Build a mental shelf of go-to examples BEFORE the exam. Pick from these 5 categories:

- **Literature** [STRETCH-5]: novels, plays, essays you've actually read. *Macbeth, The Crucible, The Great Gatsby, 1984, Beloved, A Modest Proposal*. Use **specific scenes, not vague summaries**.
- **History** [STRETCH-5]: well-known events with clear ethical or political stakes. American Revolution, Civil Rights Movement, Holocaust, fall of the Berlin Wall, women's suffrage, abolition. Use **dates, names, specifics**.
- **Current events** [STRETCH-5]: a recent event you actually know in detail (climate policy, AI debate, a specific election, a Supreme Court case). Be **factually careful**.
- **Science / research** [FLOOR-4]: studies with clear takeaways. Stanford prison experiment, Milgram, marshmallow test (controversial — be honest), placebo effect.
- **Personal experience** [FLOOR-4]: lower ceiling. Use SPARINGLY — only if it's genuinely illustrative AND you can connect it to a broader principle. Don't lead with it.

BODY PARAGRAPH STRUCTURE [5]

Each body paragraph builds ONE sub-claim with ONE strong example.

1. **TOPIC SENTENCE** — sub-claim of your thesis.
2. **EVIDENCE** — name the specific event, character, study. "In *The Great Gatsby*, Jay Gatsby's..." or "During the 1962 Cuban Missile Crisis, Kennedy..."
3. **COMMENTARY** — explain how the example illustrates your claim. **Don't just narrate — analyze.** "Gatsby's failure isn't moral — it's structural; the very market that promises mobility devours him."
4. **ZOOM-OUT** — connect this example back to your thesis and broader argument. Make it count beyond the example itself.

THE QUALIFY MOVE — sophistication built in [5]

Template thesis for qualify: "While [claim] is largely true in the context of [domain A], it overlooks [domain B], where [counterevidence] reveals that [more nuanced claim]."

Example prompt: "Failure is essential for growth."

Qualify thesis: "Failure can be a generative teacher in domains where iteration is possible — entrepreneurship, science, art — but in contexts of irreversible consequence (medicine, policy, war), the romanticization of failure obscures its real human costs. The maxim is therefore best read not as universal wisdom but as advice for **safe-to-fail** environments."

[5] This thesis hits 3 of the 4 sophistication paths simultaneously: nuanced argument (yes-but), implications (where the maxim breaks), and broader context (the conditions of "safe-to-fail").

THE "COMMENTARY DEPTH" UPGRADE [5]

A 4-scorer's commentary...	A 5-scorer's commentary...
"This shows how persistence pays off."	"What the example illustrates is not the virtue of persistence — many persistent efforts fail — but rather the conditions under which persistence yields returns: feedback loops, recoverable losses, and time horizons that allow learning to compound."
"This is similar to my point."	"This case clarifies my claim by isolating its mechanism — it's not [surface variable] that produces the outcome but [deeper variable], which my thesis tracks more precisely."

PAGE 6 | THE SOPHISTICATION VAULT · tone words, devices, signal phrases**TONE VOCABULARY — drill these. The MCQ Reading section LOVES tone questions.**

Category	Tone words to deploy
Approving / Positive	earnest, sincere, reverent, optimistic, sympathetic, compassionate, appreciative, nostalgic, hopeful, jubilant, celebratory, candid, intimate, tender
Critical / Negative	indignant, scornful, contemptuous, disdainful, dismissive, condescending, derisive, mocking, bitter, cynical, jaded, resigned, melancholic, somber
Ironic / Comic	satirical, sardonic, mocking, wry, droll, deadpan, tongue-in-cheek, irreverent, flippant, parodic, hyperbolic
Detached / Neutral	analytical, objective, journalistic, didactic, contemplative, reflective, measured, even-handed, impartial, dispassionate, matter-of-fact
Urgent / Forceful	imperative, exhortatory, impassioned, fervent, vehement, indignant, polemical, admonishing, accusatory, alarmist
Mystified / Probing	speculative, tentative, ambivalent, conflicted, perplexed, bewildered, inquisitive, philosophical, ruminative

[5] Use these in YOUR essays too — calling a passage's tone "reverent" or "sardonic" beats "serious" or "sarcastic" every time.**RHETORICAL DEVICES — the high-leverage list [5]**

Device	Definition	Example + how to talk about it in commentary
Anaphora	Repetition at start of clauses	"We shall fight on the beaches, we shall fight on the landing grounds..." — accumulates, escalates, builds rhythm and moral weight
Antithesis	Contrasted ideas in parallel structure	"Ask not what your country can do for you, ask what you can do for your country" — sharpens choice; forces reader to take sides
Parallelism	Same grammatical structure across phrases/clauses	Creates rhythm + signals equivalence; suggests the items belong together logically
Juxtaposition	Placing ideas/images side-by-side for contrast	Generates meaning by collision — letting contrast do the argumentative work without commentary
Allusion	Reference to literature, history, scripture	Borrows authority/resonance from another text without spelling it out — flatters readers' knowledge
Asyndeton	Omitting conjunctions ("I came, I saw, I conquered")	Accelerates pace; creates urgency; refuses the cushion of "and"
Polysyndeton	Adding extra conjunctions ("and... and... and...")	Slows pace; piles up; creates abundance or burden
Tricolon	Series of 3 ("life, liberty, the pursuit of happiness")	Satisfying rhythm of completion; the "rule of three" feels conclusive
Chiasmus	ABBA structure ("You can take the boy out of the country, but...")	Inverts to highlight dependence/inversion; demonstrates the speaker's verbal control
Anecdote	Short personal story used as evidence	Humanizes abstraction; gives the audience an emotional foothold; risks: small sample size
Concession	Acknowledging opposing view before refuting	Builds ethos (fair-minded) and weakens opponent's strongest punch by absorbing it
Rhetorical question	Question asked for effect, not answer	Invites the audience to supply the answer — implicates them in the argument
Direct address	Speaking to "you"/the audience	Closes distance; creates intimacy or accusation depending on context
Hyperbole	Deliberate overstatement	Signals emphasis, often comic/ironic — rarely meant literally
Understatement	Deliberate undersell	British dryness; can be more devastating than hyperbole because it trusts the audience to fill in

APPEALS — ETHOS, PATHOS, LOGOS (don't say "appeals to ethos" without explaining HOW)**Ethos** = appeal to credibility/character. *How it's built:* shared values, expertise, humility, autobiographical detail, citations of authorities.**Pathos** = appeal to emotion. *How it's built:* vivid imagery, anecdote, specific human details, stakes, charged diction.**Logos** = appeal to logic. *How it's built:* data, syllogism, cause-effect chain, definition, refutation of counterargument.**SIGNAL PHRASES THAT EARN POINTS — drop these into your essays [5]****For commentary upgrade:** "This move accomplishes..." / "The effect is to..." / "By [device], the author shifts the burden of proof to..." / "This forces the reader into..."**For sophistication:** "This argument resists simple resolution because..." / "While generally true, the case of X reveals a tension..." / "Reading this in the broader context of..." / "The implications extend beyond..."**For source integration (synthesis):** "Source A's argument that [X] hinges on an assumption that Source B directly challenges..." / "Building on Source C, but qualifying its scope..."

PAGE 7 | TRAPS, 4-vs-5 LADDER & THE WRITING DISCIPLINE

THE 4-vs-5 LADDER — what the gap actually looks like

Tier 4 student writes...	Tier 5 student writes...
"The author uses pathos to make readers feel sad."	"By foregrounding specific bodily details — the cracked walls, the child's bruised hands — the author bypasses statistical abstraction and forces the reader into proximity with consequence."
"Source A and Source B disagree."	"Source A's case for efficiency rests on a measurement premise that Source B's documentation of disparate outcomes directly invalidates: the question isn't whether testing measures <i>something</i> , but whether it measures the right thing."
"Failure can be helpful, but sometimes it isn't."	"Failure functions as teacher only in safe-to-fail environments — domains where iteration is possible and consequences recoverable. The maxim 'failure is essential for growth' romanticizes a structural condition rather than a virtue."
"This shows the author's argument."	"This exposes the load-bearing premise of the author's argument — the reliance on shared moral inheritance — which is precisely where the rhetoric is most powerful and most contestable."
Names rhetorical devices accurately	Names devices + explains rhetorical work + connects to overall purpose
Cites 3 sources in synthesis	Layers 4–5 sources, makes them argue with each other
Takes a clear position	Qualifies the position with sophistication: "true here, false there, because..."
Restates thesis in conclusion	Earns sophistication: implications, broader context, or stylistic flourish in the conclusion

THE 7 WRITING DISCIPLINES — non-negotiable habits [4]/[5]

- **[4] Sentence variety.** Don't start three sentences in a row with "The author." Mix it up: start with subordinators ("Although..."), participles ("Building on this..."), prepositional phrases ("In the second paragraph...").
- **[4] Active voice over passive.** "The argument is made by the author" → "The author argues." Cleaner, faster, scores better.
- **[4] Specific over general.** "The diction creates a serious tone" → "The clinical diction — *adjudicate, provision, stipulate* — creates a tone of legal reckoning."
- **[5] Embed brief quotes, don't lean on long ones.** Surgical 2–4 word quotes within your sentence beat block quotes that you then "explain."
- **[5] Use tone vocabulary in your own writing.** "Reverent," "sardonic," "contemplative" — write the way the readers expect a sophisticated reader to write.
- **[5] Sophisticated transitions.** Not just "however" and "therefore." Try "By contrast," "What makes this striking is," "This complicates," "Consider, however," "Beyond this lies..."
- **[5] Avoid the "in conclusion" conclusion.** Don't restate. Either: extend implications, situate in context, or end on a stylistic flourish that captures your thesis in fresh language.

COMMON MISTAKES THAT COST POINTS [4]

- **Plot summary instead of analysis** (RA essay): tells the reader what the passage says rather than HOW it works.
- **Source summary instead of integration** (Synthesis): "Source A says X. Source B says Y" without making them argue.
- **Vague evidence** (Argument): "World War II showed..." instead of "In December 1941, after Pearl Harbor..."
- **Five-paragraph rigidity:** thesis → 3 body paragraphs → conclusion. Fine for a 3, ceilings at 4. **Mix it up** — sometimes 2 robust body paragraphs > 3 thin ones.
- **Weak verbs:** "shows," "talks about," "says." Replace: "argues," "contends," "insinuates," "juxtaposes," "undercuts," "complicates."
- **"In conclusion, I have shown..."** — performative recap. Trust the reader to track your argument; spend the conclusion advancing it.
- **Name-dropping devices without explaining them:** "The author uses anaphora and antithesis." → 0 commentary points.

TEST-DAY EXECUTION CHECKLIST

For a 4 — bag ALL of these: ✓ MCQ: 27+ correct (eliminate, never blank) ✓ Each essay: clear thesis ✓ Each body paragraph: specific evidence + commentary ✓ Three full essays — never leave one blank

For a 5 — add these on top: ✓ MCQ: 33+ correct (use elimination + tone vocab) ✓ Each essay: **3+ commentary** that explains HOW evidence works (not just what it shows) ✓ At least 1–2 essays earn the **sophistication point** (qualify, situate in context, complicate) ✓ Sentence variety + active voice throughout ✓ Tone vocab + sophisticated transitions ✓ 4–5 sources in synthesis (not the minimum 3)

THE ONE THING THAT MATTERS MOST [5]: COMMENTARY DEPTH. The 4-vs-5 differentiator on every essay isn't WHAT you cite — it's HOW deeply you analyze. After every piece of evidence, ask yourself: "Did I just describe what's there, or did I explain what it DOES?" If you only described, you're at a 3. If you explained the rhetorical work, you're at a 4. **If you explained the work AND its complications, you're at a 5.**

If you do nothing else: master the device→effect→purpose pattern (Page 3), the source-integration move (Page 4), and the qualify thesis (Page 5). That's how you get the score you're targeting.

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